Replace the mussels with shell-on shrimp in this Flemish soup if you prefer; peel, and add the empty shells to the reduced stock for 3 minutes before straining.

waterzooi (flemish stew)

SERVES 4 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

1 large waxy potato, peeled
1 large carrot, peeled
1 medium-large zucchini
1 bunch asparagus
10oz (300g) monkfish
1 sole, filleted and skinned
2½ cups chicken or fish stock
½ cup dry white wine
3 large scallions, finely chopped
1lb 2oz (500g) mussels, rinsed and scrubbed
½ cup heavy (whipping) cream
salt and freshly ground black pepper
1 tbsp finely chopped tarragon, to serve

1 Cut the potato and carrot in ½ x 2in (1 x 5cm) batons. Slice the zucchini into diagonal pieces. Cut off the asparagus tips, then chop the spears into 2in (5cm) lengths. Cut the monkfish into 1½in (4cm) chunks and cut each sole fillet crosswise in half. Set the vegetables and fish aside separately.

2 Place the stock, wine, and scallions (reserving a few to serve) in a heavy saucepan. Bring to a boil over medium heat. Add the potato, reduce the heat to a simmer, and cook for 5 minutes, then add the carrot and cook for 5 minutes. Add the zucchini and asparagus and cook for 1–2 minutes, or until all is *al dente*. Remove the vegetables and set aside.

3 Bring the stock to a boil over high heat and reduce by a third. Reduce the heat to a simmer, add in the mussels, cover and cook for 3–4 minutes. Strain through a muslin-lined sieve into a bowl, let cool briefly, then discard any mussels that haven't opened. Shell the rest and set aside. Return the stock to the pan and simmer over medium heat, then stir in the cream and season to taste with salt and pepper. Add the monkfish, cook for 2–3 minutes, then the sole for 1 minute, then the vegetables and mussels for a final 2 minutes.

4 Using a slotted spoon, distribute the vegetables between the bowls. Place the fish on top, ladle over the broth, and scatter with mussels. Sprinkle with chopped tarragon and the reserved scallion. Serve hot.